It

WAS 4 IN THE EVENING ON FEBRUARY 7 and the winter light had begun to fade. Nitish Kumar's team started looking a tad anxious, but the Bihar chief minister, otherwise a stickler for time and routine, seemed oblivious, enjoying his extended public interactions in Munger district that day. According to the itinerary, though, he was two hours behind and the helipad in Sheikhpura district, from where he was to take the 30-minute chopper flight to Patna, was 80-odd kilometres away.

There were other options, of course—Nitish could skip a few stopovers to be in time for the state helicopter (which can fly only during day hours for security reasons) or do the journey by car, which meant another three and a half hours on the road. It had been a long and gruelling day, with 14 pitstops already in Munger, but, as many in the 71-year-old CM's team had feared, he immediately turned down the chopper idea and said, "Let the helicopter fly back to Patna without us." Nitish was to take the journey by road and, in between, have another five stopovers to meet the public in the Lakhisarai and Sheikhpura districts.

Four months after snapping ties with the Bharatiya Janata Party-led National Democratic Alliance, Nitish had embarked on a Samadhan Yatra across the state on January 5, to be concluded on February 16. The shifting of political allegiances in August 2022 has left the eight-term CM—the Janata Dal (United) chief has ruled Bihar since November 2005, barring a nine-month self-imposed hiatus in May 2014—with a new set of challenges, the 2024 Lok Sabha election being the biggest. The yatra, covering all 38 districts of the state, was in a sense a precursor to the long campaign that lies ahead. From Katihar in the east to the two Champarans on the northern tip, and from Buxar and Bhojpur in the west to Gaya and Nawada in the south, Nitish's travels followed a pattern that suggested that he was putting a plan in action.

Bihar was in the midst of a biting cold wave when the yatra took off on January 5. By the second week of February, the weather had changed and his muffler and overcoat was replaced by a khadi kurta and sleeveless *bandi* (jacket). A typical yatra day sees Nitish reaching the district by state helicopter, and then travelling to carefully chosen rural locations. The focus is always on making direct contact, from walking the village streets to taking petitions and complaints from the jostling crowd to encouraging school girls as they sang a pro-prohibition ditty, Nitish has tried to be one with the people, willing to lend a ear to anyone with a thought or a plaint.

UNDERLYING NARRATIVES

These are challenging times for Nitish. His erstwhile allies, the BJP and Chirag Paswan's Lok Janshakti Party (LJP)-R, have joined hands, which is likely to add 5-6

RANJAN RAHI



PLOTTING THE WAY AHEAD

Nitish's challenges

- After an **UNDERWHELMING 2020 ASSEMBLY ELECTION**, Nitish needs to bounce back in the 2024 Lok Sabha election to stay relevant
- He may be the only CM whose political fortunes seem inextricably linked to the **LS POLL RESULTS**. He has announced that deputy and RJD chief Tejashwi Yadav will lead the Mahagathbandhan in the 2025 assembly polls
- The Bihar CM's biggest challenge will be **STRIKING A BALANCE** between his JD(U) partymen—who may be unwilling to go with Tejashwi's leadership in 2025—and the RJD men for whom his CM candidature is non-negotiable
- The BJP and party rebel Upendra Kushwaha are trying to sow **SEEDS OF CONFUSION** in the JD(U) on the above point., Nitish has privately spoken to partymen to clear the air
- The BJP has **STITCHED A DEAL** with Chirag Paswan, who comes with 5-6% Paswan voters. Nitish's task is to ensure the remaining EBCs stay onboard for a better chance in the LS election
- **BIHAR OF 2023** is different from what it was in 2015 when Nitish and Lalu effortlessly merged their vote banks